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Emma Wiles (née van Inwegen)

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Academic Position & Affiliations

Isabel Anderson Career Development Professor, Boston University 2025-
Assistant Professor, Boston University 2024-
Information Systems, Questrom School of Business
Faculty Affiliate, Human Resources Policy Institute, Boston University 2026-
Visiting Scholar, Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis Summer 2026
Digital Fellow, Initiative on the Digital Economy, Massachusetts Institute of Technology 2024-
Faculty Fellow, Digital Business Institute, Boston University 2025-

Education

PhD Management, Massachusetts Institute of Technology 2019-2024
Dissertation title: *Artificial Intelligence in Labor Market Matching*
Committee members: *John Horton, Catherine Tucker, Dean Eckles*
MS Management Research, Massachusetts Institute of Technology 2019-2022
BA Mathematics, Economics, University of Washington 2011-2015

Teaching Experience

BU IS223 Introduction to Information Systems Fall 2024, 2025, 2026
MIT 15.818 MBA Level Pricing (TA) Fall 2023
MIT 15.567 MBA Level Economics of Information: Strategy, Structure and Pricing (TA) Spring 2023
MIT 15.575 PhD Level Economics of Information and Information Technology (TA) Spring 2022

Professional Service

Platform Strategy Research Symposium, Scientific Committee 2026
Conference on Digital Experimentation, Technical Committee 2020, 2021, 2024, 2025 Questrom
Junior Faculty Brown Bag, Organizer 2026

Served as referee for:
Management Science, Journal of Human Resources, Information Systems Research, International Conference on Information Systems, MISQ, Quarterly Journal of Economics, Journal of Public Economics, Economics of Education Review, American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, American Economic Review: Insights

Fellowships, Honors, and Awards

Isabel Anderson Career Development Professorship ($90,000) 2025-2028
Economics of AI Stripe Fellowship ($10,000) 2025
PhD Thesis Award in Artificial Intelligence in Entrepreneurship and Management (AIEM) *University of Padova* (€5,000) 2024
Microsoft Research Grant for *AI and the Future of Work* ($50,000) 2023
Zenon S. Zannetos Memorial Fellowship (MIT) 2020-2023
MIT Graduate Student Fellowship 2019-2020

Invited Seminars

McGill University, World Bank, Minneapolis Federal Reserve, University of Minnesota

Publications

Algorithmic Writing Assistance on Jobseekers' Resumes Increases Hires (with Zanele Munyikwa and John Horton), 2025
Published in Management Science

- Media coverage: MarketWatch, Business Insider, Yahoo News

There is a strong association between the quality of the writing in a resume for new labor market entrants and whether those entrants are ultimately hired. We show that this relationship is, at least partially, causal: a field experiment in an online labor market was conducted with nearly half a million jobseekers in which a treated group received algorithmic writing assistance. Treated jobseekers experienced an 8% increase in the probability of getting hired. Contrary to concerns that the assistance is taking away a valuable signal, we find no evidence that employers were less satisfied. We present a model in which better writing is not a signal of ability but helps employers ascertain ability, which rationalizes our findings.

Why You Shouldn't Call AI Agents Employees (with Megan Hsu, Lisa Krayer, Julie Bedard, and Matt Kropp), 2026
Published in Harvard Business Review
As organizations experiment with placing AI agents on org charts as "employees," new research shows this framing has unintended consequences. In a large-scale experiment, anthropomorphizing AI reduced individual accountability, increased unnecessary escalation, lowered review quality, and heightened employee uncertainty about their roles—without improving adoption. The findings suggest the core challenge is not whether to deploy agentic AI, but how to redesign workflows, roles, and governance so humans remain clearly accountable while effectively supervising increasingly capable systems.

Generative AI and the Temporary Upskilling of Knowledge Workers (with Lisa Krayer, Mohamed Abbadi, Urvi Awasthi, Ryan Kennedy, Pamela Mishkin, Francois Candelon, Daniel Sack), 2026.
Published in Nature Human Behaviour

"Upskilling" often refers to the process by which workers acquire and expand their skills, enabling them to perform different types of work as market demands change.This paper demonstrates that while generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) can act as an "exoskeleton," enhancing workers' capabilities while they attempt new skills, these gains are dependent on the continued use of the technology. When the "exoskeleton" is removed, little to no knowledge is retained independently, revealing that the newfound capabilities are temporary and reliant on the external support provided by GenAI. We run a randomized controlled trial on "upskilling" with GenAI by providing Boston Consulting Group (BCG) consultants with access and training in using ChatGPT to solve technical problems. We measure their performance on real data science tasks outside their skill sets, which cannot be independently solved by ChatGPT. Treated workers score 49, 20, and 18 percentage points higher than those in the control group on the three tasks and perform close to the level of real BCG data scientists on two of the three tasks. However, treated workers are no better at answering technical questions without the use of ChatGPT post-experiment, suggesting their demonstrated newfound technical capabilities do not imply knowledge acquisition.

Minimum Wage Increases and Low-Wage Employment: Evidence from Seattle (with Ekaterina Jardim, Mark Long, Robert Plotnick, Jacob Vigdor, Hilary Wething) 2022.
Published in American Economic Journal: Economic Policy

- Media coverage: The Economist, FiveThirtyEight, Los Angeles Times, New York Times, New York Times (The Upshot), Seattle Times, Washington Post
- Presented at: ASSA 2016, APPAM Fall Conference 2016

Seattle raised its minimum wage to as much as $11 in 2015 and as much to $13 in 2016. We use Washington State administrative data to conduct two complementary analyses of its impact. Relative to outlying regions of the state identified by the synthetic control method, aggregate employment at wages less than twice the original minimum, measured by total hours worked, declined. A portion of this reduction reflects jobs transitioning to wages above the threshold; the aggregate analysis likely overstates employment effects. Longitudinal analysis of individual Seattle workers matched to counterparts in outlying regions reveals no change in the probability of

continued employment, but significant reductions in hours particularly for less-experienced workers. Job turnover declined, as did hiring of new workers into low-wage jobs. Analyses suggest aggregate employment elasticities in the range of -0.2 to -2.0, concentrated on the intensive margin in the short run and largest among inexperienced workers.

Boundary Discontinuity Methods in the Presence of Policy Spillovers (with Ekaterina Jardim, Mark Long, Robert Plotnick, Jacob Vigdor) 2022.
Published in the Journal of Public Economics

The boundary discontinuity method of causal inference may yield misleading results if a policy's impacts do not stop at the border of the implementing jurisdiction. We use geographically precise longitudinal employment data documenting worker job-to-job mobility to study policy spillovers in the context of three local minimum wage increases. Estimated spillover impacts on wages and hours are statistically significant, geographically diffuse, and sufficient to create concern regarding interpretation of results even using not-immediately-adjacent regions as controls. Spillover effects appear less concerning with smaller interventions or those adopted in a smaller jurisdiction.

Working papers

More, but Worse: The Marketplace Effects of AI-Generated Job Posts (with John Horton), 2025.
Revise and Resubmit at Management Science

- Media coverage: New York Times

Generative AI makes it dramatically cheaper to produce the information that labor markets rely on for hiring—but cheaper communication need not improve matching. We consider the effects of the introduction of a generative AI tool in a large scale field experiment on an online labor market, which lowered employers' search costs by randomly offering them AI-written first drafts of their job post. The assistance was widely accepted and treated employers were 19 % more likely to post a job. It also saved employers time—treated employers spent 44% less time writing their job posts. Despite the substantial increase in job posts, there was no discernible increase in matches in the treatment group. We provide evidence that the treated job posts were more generic and less informative to jobseekers. This combination of increased job post volume and reduced informativeness diluted signals of employer seriousness. A time-cost accounting implies jobseeker application time costs are roughly six times larger than employer time savings per treated employer. In a subsequent platform roll-out expanding the access of the AI tool, posting responses attenuated while lower hiring conditional on posting remained, suggesting that learning and increased adoption did not eliminate these frictions.

Putting AI on the Org Chart: Evidence on Delegation and Oversight (with Megan Hsu, Julie Bedard, and Matt Kropp).

- Media coverage: New York Times

Firms are increasingly deploying agentic AI systems capable of independent action. Some have begun integrating these agents into their organizational structures, assigning them designated roles and responsibilities and referring to them as employees. This creates new challenges for managers' decisions about when to delegate and how to monitor work. In a survey of 1,261 managers, 23% report that their organizations list AI agents on organizational or workflow charts. In a randomized experiment, we provide those managers with identical documents containing built-in errors and ask them to review them. We vary whether the drafts are presented as produced by an AI tool, an AI employee, or a human employee. Average effects on error catching are small. However, among managers whose organizations *already* list AI agents on their org charts, we find evidence consistent with a "hot potato" effect: managers catch fewer errors themselves, request more review by others, and assign less accountability to themselves. Presenting drafts as produced by an AI employee rather than an AI tool reduces the share of errors detected by 17%, increases requests for additional review by 22 percentage points, and shifts perceived accountability toward the AI system. Compared with managers reviewing an AI employee's work, those reviewing a human employee's work flag more errors themselves and are less likely to request additional review, suggesting that this pattern is not simply a response to delegation. These results suggest that how organizations position AI should be understood as a governance decision that impacts how managers oversee work.

The Diminishing Returns to Human Recruiting in Online Labor Markets (with John Fallon and John Horton)

Employers often rely on outside recruiters to find workers, but it is unclear whether human intermediaries add value when employers already have access to algorithmic screening tools. We study a randomized experiment in a large online labor market that assigned human recruiting assistance to 83,017 vacancies. The recruiters increased the search and screening intensity of treated job posts: treated job posts had more recruiting and more applicant screening done on their behalf, resulting in 5% more applicants. Employers of treated job posts redirected their own screening efforts toward recruiter-sourced candidates and away from applicants who found the post on their own. Despite the increase in search intensity, treated employers were no more likely to hire than employers of control posts with access only to algorithmic tools. Match quality appears at best, no better for the hires that resulted from the treated job posts, and treated employers were less likely to return to the platform to post a second vacancy after the experiment. We develop a model of delegated recruiting in which recruiters and employers rely on a common noisy signal; it predicts that recruiting adds value when the recruiter brings information the algorithm lacks and can subtract value when the two parties' assessments are correlated. Consistent with the model's screening mechanism, recruited applicants are positively selected on observable characteristics yet do not improve hiring outcomes. These findings suggest that as algorithmic screening improves, the scope for intermediaries to add value shrinks because it becomes harder to access independent information.

Research in Progress

Workers Responses to Price Uncompetitiveness: Evidence from a Field Experiment (with Apostolos Filippas and John Horton)

If and how to regulate online marketplaces is an open question important to both platform designers and policy makers. Using a large field experiment in an online labor market, we analyze the effects of a platform minimum wage. Workers were randomly assigned individual price floors which prevented treated workers from bidding hourly rates below their floor. Workers for whom the floor was likely binding—those historically bidding below the floor—suffered a decline in job-finding probability(30%), but higher wages conditional upon being hired(9%). Treated workers made lower earnings overall, but higher earnings conditional on working at least one hour on the platform. Despite a job being "worth more" if hired, affected workers lowered their search intensity. They did not move to the "uncovered sector"—jobs with a fixed price rather than an hourly wage, nor did they direct their search to better fitting jobs. They were also more likely to exit the platform. After the conclusion of the experiment, the platform rolled out the $3 per hour minimum wage platform wide, allowing us to observe the the employment outcomes and job search behavior in equilibrium.

AI Competence as Human Capital (with Katelyn Cranney)

Generative AI can raise productivity, but realized gains depend on how workers use the tool. We study AI competence as a form of human capital defined by the practical ability to organize work with a model, evaluate its output, and retain judgment while using it to extend one's existing skills. In a preregistered lab-in-the-field experiment, 332 full-time management consultants whose jobs did not routinely require coding were assigned a difficult Python data-analysis task with or without access to a Gen AI tool. AI access increased scores by 34 percentage points, raised completion by 7 percentage points, reduced time on the task by 12%, and improved debugging efficiency. We open the black box of these gains by combining Gen AI transcripts, code-execution logs, task outputs, and surveys. Using an ethnography-inspired agentic coding procedure, we identify nine distinct AI-collaboration practices that capture how workers frame requests, decompose problems, rely on generated code, edit independently, verify outputs, and manage scope. These practices explain substantial heterogeneity in overall performance. Gains concentrate when workers engage proactively with AI while retaining substantive judgment. Finally, we show that productivity gains and workers' interpretation of those gains are distinct. AI access does not significantly increase average confidence, trust, enjoyment, or behavioral trust in AI, and belief responses vary substantially by gender and prior coding experience. The results suggest that firms should treat AI training as human-capital investment, teaching workers not only how to prompt, but how to divide labor with AI, evaluate its output, and build confidence in using it well.

The Use and Governance of AI Agents in U.S. Firms (with Innessa Colaiacovo)

Autonomous AI agents have been forecast to change work and organizations, but evidence about how they are used is scarce. Drawing on a survey of 1,500 full-time senior managers, we provide some of the first systematic evidence about the diffusion of AI agents, defined a tool able to take actions and complete tasks on its own. Just over half of all managers surveyed report that their organization has at least one AI agent built into its work processes, but fewer than half of these managers indicate they are aware of a formal policy that governs the use of agents at their organization. The correlation between integrating AI agents into work and enacting policies to govern them is positive but small, suggesting that integrating and governing agents might be separate sets of choices made by organizations. These results suggest that AI agents are diffusing broadly, but also highlight substantial variation in whether and how firms are changing work and policies in response, which may affect agents' ultimate impacts.

Invited presentations

Columbia's Management, Analytics, and Data Conference	2026
World Bank	2026
Federal Reserve Bank at Minneapolis	2026
University of Minnesota, Work & Organizations	2026
McGill University, Information Systems	2026
Columbia's Management, Analytics, and Data Conference	2024
National Association for Business Economics Tech Economic Conference Lightning Talk	2023
Wharton, Conference on Business & AI Presentation	2023
NBER Summer Institute Digital Economics and AI Lighting Round Talk	2023
Conference on the Economics of Information & Communication Technologies Presentation	2023
ASSA/AEA, Labor and Employment Relations Association Presentation	2023
NBER Digitization Tutorial	2022
NBER Economics of Privacy Conference	2022
INFORMS, Platforms Presentation	2022
Workshop on Information Systems (WISE) & Economics, Platforms Presentation	2022
Conference on Digital Experimentation, Presentation	2020

Personal Details

Language: English (Native)
Citizenship: USA
Husband: Edward Wiles, Trade and Development Economist
Baby: Penelope Wiles, unemployed